

# Class of 76 Biographies



Celebrating 50 Years Since Leaving Friends' School

*Cover photograph courtesy of Diane Drayne*

# Introduction

It is 50 years since the 'Class of 76' left Friends' School Lisburn. To mark the occasion class members were invited to submit a short biography outlining how their lives had unfolded since then. Some 50 class members have responded, generously sharing a short synopsis of their lives together with a current picture. This is an excellent response considering that we have inevitably lost contact with some class members over the years.

'Class of 76' is something of a misnomer since our group also includes members who left Friends' before 1976, and some of their stories are included in the following pages.

92 pupils graduated from Friends' in the summer of 1976; 20 went into employment and 72 into further education. Of these, 23 pursued further education in Britain and 2 in the Republic of Ireland with the balance remaining in Northern Ireland, predominantly studying at Queen's University Belfast.

Sadly a number of friends are no longer with us, including at least 8 of those who graduated in 1976.

Class members who responded include 13 based in England, 6 in Scotland and others further afield in Belgium, Canada, New Zealand and Zimbabwe, with the balance in Ireland.

The initiative of collating these biographies was undertaken in the spirit of understanding what became of a group educated in Northern Ireland during the challenging years of the 1970s. The stories which follow show that despite the difficult circumstances in which our secondary education took place, class members have gone on to lead fulfilling lives. We did ok!

The accounts provided are by turns humorous, reflective, honest, touching, boastful, self-deprecating and modest, but always informative and enjoyable.

The biographies are organised in alphabetical order by surname in use while at school. Where surnames have since changed, the current surname is shown in brackets (with one exception). An index is provided for easy reference.

This second edition includes includes two additional biographies, bringing the total to 52.

Timothy Smith, May 2026

# Biographies



# John Barr

Based in Lisburn / Ballinderry

I studied medicine at Queen's University Belfast, beginning a career that would span more than 40 years. After completing house officer and registrar posts in NI and brief spells in Birmingham, UK and several centres in USA gaining valuable experience in trauma and orthopaedic oncology, I was appointed as a consultant trauma & orthopaedic surgeon to The Royal Victoria and Musgrave Park Hospitals in Belfast in 1993. A role held through to retirement in 2022.

Away from work, family has always been central. I am married to Karen (an old scholar) and we have three daughters, two of whom currently live in the Greater London area and the other in Copenhagen.

Retirement has provided more time to enjoy favourite pastimes, including golf, tennis, gardening, walking, reading, travel and listening to music. A particularly special milestone came recently when Karen and I fulfilled a long-held ambition to visit all seven continents—a dream many years in the making.



After a long and busy surgical career, life is now a little slower but still active and enjoyable. Weekday morning coffee at 10:30 often coincides with Radio 2's music quiz, "Ten to the Top" – I have never had a full score of 65 but will continue to try!

At time of writing, I remain in good health, with many of my original parts intact!

# Robert Beatty

Based in Lambeg

Currently living in Lambeg, closer to FSL than when I took the train every school day from Finaghy. Married to Rhonda since 1982 with one daughter Gemma who is a lecturer in genetics at QUB. After FSL, I got a degree in Pure Maths from QUB – where I discovered that I didn't want to do pure maths for the rest of my life. I became a statistician working in the private and public sectors and was responsible for, among other things, the (Northern Ireland) Census of Population in 2011.

I'm still into music in a big way, and still happy to assert that the 1970's had the best music. My first proper music concert was Lindisfarne in the Ulster Hall in 1974 and 51 years later saw them again in 2025 in the Mandala Hall – with hundreds of concerts in between. Also still following Northern Ireland at football, and latterly Ulster at rugby. Given up most active sports, but am still running regularly, although it's gentle 5km jogs these days.



Main activities these days are reading (history, economics and fiction) and travel. Managed to travel to pretty much every country in Europe (not quite all of them) and a few further afield. Favourite country so far is Georgia and hoping to be able to get back to Ukraine soon – amazing country. As I write this, off to Cyprus next week, if DJ Trump behaves himself.

*With Mikhail Bulgakov in Kiev*

# Adrian Bell

Based in Lisburn

Prior to starting Business Studies at Jordanstown Polytechnic, Robert Wiggins and I spent the summer of 76 picking peaches in Canada – a memorable time!

Then after graduation I worked for the Guinness Group whilst studying for the Wine & Spirit Education Trust (WSET) Certificate, Higher Certificate and Diploma and became the wine rep for the Guinness Group in NI.



Charlotte and I were married in 1982 and living in Crumlin, the troubles were causing concern, so we moved to Glasgow.

We managed 2 pubs on Sauchiehall Street, dodging the odd Glasgow kiss.

Christmas 1989 our son Gordon arrived, it was time to return home, Gordon was diagnosed with Cerebral Palsy and needed 24/7 care. Our daughter Julie arrived in 1991.

During this time, I worked for a local wine importer whilst studying for financial services qualifications. In August 1992 I joined Legal & General and worked as a financial consultant for 13 years and in 2005 I left L&G to start my own IFA practice; Succeed Wealth Management Ltd which was sold to Amber River Ltd allowing me to retire at Christmas 2025.

# Jenny Bell (Long)

Based in Co Down

On leaving school 50 (aagh!) years ago, I studied French and Drama at Exeter University, followed by a postgraduate year at Drama School in London. This kick started a period of work as a professional actor in young people's theatre based in Liverpool and London with tours in the UK and the USA.

I then trained as a Drama Teacher, got married to Danny (celebrating our 40<sup>th</sup> Wedding Anniversary this year!), and had two children, who are all grown up now and starting families of their own. After living in East London for 15 years, we decided to move back to live in the Co Down countryside and I began teaching Performing Arts alongside working as a freelance director/drama facilitator with local theatre companies, including The Lyric Theatre, Tinderbox, Replay and Big Telly. Somewhere in all of that I completed a Masters in 2007 and currently I am still working part-time, teaching Voice and Text at Mountview Theatre Academy in Belfast and run a drama group of highly creative ladies (and one gent) based in Ards.



Recent highlights include performing at the Edinburgh Fringe, devising and performing in a children's show for the Young at Art Festival, and volunteering at Glastonbury. Travel has taken me to Iceland, Spain, Greece, Italy, and France. I am enjoying getting back to sailing and keep active with Yoga and Pilates since taking part in our Class of '76 Marathon Relay Team!

Looking forward to reconnecting with our classmates in June!

# Martyn Bird

Based in Wiltshire

Leaving Lisburn on 18 Jun 1976, I joined the Army.

I was fortunate to travel all over the world and promote fairly regularly. My main employ was Royal Military Police Officer, and my secondary trade was Close Protection Operative (Protecting Senior Officers, British Ambassadors and travelling senior Cabinet Ministers). My trail of postings included, Germany 5 times, Belize, Yugoslavia, Zaire, Lebanon, Bosnia, Kosovo, Norway, Turkey, Israel, Sinai, Syria, London, Edinburgh and NI, 4 times.

Post military career I continued to travel and tout my skills as a Security Risk Consultant in places like Kazakhstan, Yemen and Syria.

After playing a lot of contact team sport, I took up Ultra Marathoning and have competed in 300 - 500km races in China, Chile, Portugal, one solo effort from the Somme to the NMA and a few 100km events in UK.

I've headed up security for a couple of Ultra High Net Worth Families and spent my last 3 years prior to retirement back at Army Headquarters working for the RMP. I now work to advise and help friends who are still in the risk business.



None of this would have been achieved without Jackie by my side and with our two wonderful children Alexandra and Oliver, we've had a whale of a time, and I consider myself to be a very lucky man.

My proudest military moment has to be commanding the RMP in my home city and presenting my Company on Parade to the GOC in Thiepval Barracks. With my mother watching on.

# Jenny Boyd

Based in Belfast / Donegal

After Stranmillis College I taught in Harmony Hill PS, Lead Hill PS and Bangor Central PS. Having completed my degree in educational studies with PE I involved myself in schools' gymnastics as well as many other sports.

Following on from that involvement I found myself on a group rewriting the PE curriculum and then worked with the Education Authority in supporting its implementation.

In the mid 90's I headed west to teach in Enniskillen firstly in the Model PS and then established Enniskillen Nursery school where I was principal for nearly 20 years. I even went to the Palace to receive an MBE for services to education.



Life however was not always about working! I have played hockey, squash, tennis and always golf. Holidays featured too. Having a house in Donegal means I have spent summers there and now in retirement spend winters in Belfast.

I did volunteer to go on a trip to India to support teachers in a community outside Dahra Dunn in the foothills of the Himalayas. It was in memory of SAS our RE teacher Sydney Stewart who taught in the first room down the blue corridor!!

# Hazel Browne (Armstrong)

Based in Carrickfergus

A wee, shy 18 year old girl, Hazel Browne, left Friends' in 1976. In fact, in Miss Clayton's A level English class, when she couldn't recall my name, she explained that I was one of those pupils who merged in with the surroundings!

I attended Stranmillis College, Belfast, undertaking a Bachelor of Education degree, graduating in the summer of 1980. I completed a two year Advanced Certificate in Nursery Education at St. Mary's College, Belfast. I taught in Monkstown Nursery School and became Principal in 1996, remaining there until I retired in 2016.

I married John Armstrong in 1981. We have two children and we have two granddaughters.

I love knitting, travelling to yarn festivals in England, Scotland, the Shetland Islands and regularly attending the New York Sheep and Wool Festival in the Hudson Valley.

I have discovered a love of pottery and enjoy immersive workshops in South-West France. I am a member of Belfast Ceramics Studio. I am a member of International Ceramics Art Network and have travelled with them to Portugal on a culture and ceramics tour. These creative interests have lain dormant in my soul since first form at Friends' where nerdy Hazel chose Latin instead of Domestic Science and German, instead of Art and Music!



It's fifty years since we left Friends' School Lisburn. Unbelievable! They say that your school days are the best days of your life. But retirement years come a close second!

# George Bryans

Based in Lisburn

I am married with two grown children.

I left Friends' in 1974 after my O-levels and went to work in the Halifax Building Society. I initially viewed this as a short term job but it ended up becoming a career for me, I stayed there in various roles until 2010 when I applied for early retirement (aged 52).

Alongside working I enjoyed outdoor activities which included sea-kayaking and long distance running. In 2006 I kayaked from NI to Scotland to raise funds for a local charity, in 2008 I did another charity kayak from NI to the Isle of Man and in 2009 we kayaked around Lough Neagh (80 miles approx.). In 2011 I kayaked the river Shannon from source to sea to fundraise for a charity which helps out in Uganda. I have completed a number of ultra-marathons including a 100 mile race in Scotland, again to raise funds for a local charity.

Since retiring I have worked in a charity for pre-school children (Early Years) and I have been volunteering at Habitat for Humanity in Lisburn for the past nine years. In 1998 I learned Transcendental Meditation and I continue to regularly meditate.

## ISLE OF MAN... BY CANOE



I suppose after attending Friends' I was always curious about Quakers and in 2024 I attended a Quaker meeting in our old school and decided that I would like to be part of that community as it fitted in with my beliefs. I am now a regular attendee at the South Belfast Quakers.

# Keith Campbell

Based in Hillsborough

After leaving school, I went on to study Civil Engineering at Queen's University Belfast, before setting out on what I thought would be my career in the field. It didn't take too long, however, to realise that life had other plans, and I soon found my way to Shorts, where I spent the rest of my working days as an aeronautical engineer.

Alison and I settled in the village of Hillsborough early on and, finding it hard to better, have stayed put ever since. We have two girls and are now proud grandparents to three, which keeps life lively and ensures there's never a dull moment.

Retired these past eight years, I've taken to a quieter pace—at least in theory. I'm a regular on the golf course, where optimism tends to outpace performance, and I've also taken up watercolour painting, with results that are, on a good day, not half bad.

A fair bit of my time is spent minding the grandchildren, a role I approach with great enthusiasm and varying degrees of success. I remain a loyal supporter of Ulster Rugby, following them through thick and thin, mostly thin, to be honest it's more about having a few beers and a bit of craic with old mates.

I'm very much looking forward to seeing a few familiar faces again, swapping stories, and picking up where we left off all those years ago.



# Maureen Campbell

Based in Belfast

50 years! Where has it gone?

50 years on sees me retired from my job as a teacher, for many years at P3 level, having concluded my career in an Acting Principal's role for the most of my final 5 years. I have also spent most of those 50 years volunteering for Scouts NI at many levels from local to regional level, having led the Beaver Scout section in the province for 7 years, either side of the millennium. Northern Ireland, as we all know is such a small place, and I am delighted that Arthur Chapman's grandson is now the Scout Leader in my Scout Group. I had the pleasure of 'walking down memory lane' with Mr Chapman at Duncan's wedding a few years ago.



Having retired almost 10 years ago, Alan and I are keen travellers and hikers, and we have travelled to many countries, but not the hot ones! We will just have returned from our latest adventures in New Zealand when we all meet in June. I have dabbled a little with art in my retirement and have enjoyed painting some of our favourite places.

It has also been lovely to meet up with some of you for coffee from time to time and to hear about all your lives and adventures too, and I am looking forward to meeting more of you on the 6<sup>th</sup> June.

# Ivor Cartmill

Based in Lancashire

I graduated from Edinburgh University with a BSc in medical microbiology and MB ChB in 1982. I trained in Newcastle and Manchester and was appointed a consultant to Pennine Acute NHS Trust - that's Rochdale, Oldham, Bury, and North Manchester. At school these were just dots in Mr Jamieson's O-level geography Lancashire map, but I worked there for 27 years. My special research interest was hospital-acquired diarrhoea (someone had to do it).



More interesting things:

- 1) According to Ancestry gene testing I am 71% Scottish which is hardly surprising as three grandparents had lowland Scots surnames. No other shocks though.
- 2) I met my wife Alison at the STD diagnostics bench (as a fellow worker, not as a patient) in 1988 and have been married since 1994.
- 3) We have two daughters: Eleanor (30) an NHS manager and playwright; and Caroline (28) a primary school teacher.
- 4) I am a serious quizzer, a harmless arcane activity, in the Withington Quiz League [www.withquiz.co.uk](http://www.withquiz.co.uk) which also happily coincides with recreational beer drinking.
- 5) Retirement activities: piano lessons (but still hopeless), walking (preferably on the flat), watching my wife gardening (to ensure she does not accidentally dig up the five guinea pigs buried in shoeboxes), watching my weight, watching Lancashire CCC at Old Trafford.
- 6) Didsbury Good Neighbours Men's Group - where we reflect that when we were young, we thought we knew everything, but no one listened; and now we do know everything, but still no one listens.

# Madeline Christie (McCoy)

Based in Lisburn

I left Friends' in 1974 after 'O' levels and attended Lisburn Tech as it was then known. My teaching and learning stood me in good stead for my 2 years there doing a pre-nursing course. I began my nurse training in January 1977 in Lagan Valley Hospital to do my SEN training. I remained in nursing since then & retired from my permanent post as Deputy Sister in January this year though I am continuing with a Staff Nurse role on the nurse bank in LVH. Along the way I nursed in Windsor House BCH, Lisadian Private Nursing Home in Hillsborough and following completion of my conversion course through Queen's University secured a Staff Nurse post in LVH in 2000 where I retired from after 25 years there. I occasionally even met some of you guys during my nursing career when taking care of relatives.

Outside of work I have 3 of a family, 2 daughters and 1 son and 1 granddaughter to date who keep me occupied. I have been a parent governor and am currently a Transferors Representative BOG at Ballycarrickmaddy Primary School Upper Ballinderry for around 20 years now!! I have been an Officer in Magheragall Presbyterian Girls Brigade for around 30 years.



Lastly but more importantly I remain friends with my closest school friends, Sandra and Dorothy Green (Thompson) and we and June Champion (Turner) & Alma Ferguson have more recently enjoyed meeting up over a few lunch dates & reminisce about our time at school. I may not have excelled in any particular area but have always been very proud to say that I attended Friends' School.

# Aileen Colhoun

Based in London

After leaving FSL I studied Law at Bristol, followed by a Masters in Criminology at Cambridge and my solicitors' professional exams at the College of Law in London. I have lived in London ever since!

As my passion was criminal law, I trained at a specialist criminal law firm - Kingsley Napley - qualifying as a solicitor in 1983. I worked there for a few years on some high profile cases, the most notorious of which was probably Jeremy Bamber, convicted of murdering his entire family at their farmhouse in Essex.

Since then I have worked in a number of different practices, always defending, never prosecuting, getting to know London through its police stations, magistrates courts, Crown courts and prisons.

I retired over 2 years ago, and now keep myself amused with local Labour Party politics, membership of an organisation called Women in Criminal Law of which I am joint secretary, Tai Chi, Mindfulness and going to the theatre and art galleries as often as I can afford!



Last but not least I'm learning Irish Gaelic. I know I'm not the only one from our year learning Irish! It's almost impossible, but I love it. It's a fantastic way to connect with the Irish culture.

My mother is now 91, living in Castlerock on the north coast and my brother Alan has been living back in Co Derry for 7 years now. I have a 27 year old son who is very much a Londoner and he's the one who will keep me here in London.

Looking forward to seeing you all again.

# Laura Cooper (Davies)

Based in Cheshire

After graduating in Modern and Mediaeval Languages from Cambridge University, I completed 2 years of postgraduate studies in international marketing, before moving to Germany to work for a French multinational.



In 1983 I returned to the UK to join ICI, learning the ropes first as a sales rep in Northwest England, followed by three incredible years travelling behind the 'Iron Curtain', negotiating entire years' supplies of chemicals often by bartering, due to lack of hard currency under the centrally planned Soviet system. After a number of roles in ICI, I moved into Management Consultancy with Andersen Consulting and then KMPG.

By now I was married to Neil and, with two children 'under two', I decided to work from home (a bit of a novelty back then) and formed a marketing consultancy for SMEs in the knowledge sector. I gradually started focusing more on international education and in 2014 set up a new business delivering residential courses based in Cambridge University to help British and International schoolchildren develop the skills and confidence needed for university applications. Over the following years, I travelled throughout India, Middle East and China, including joining a delegation to Singapore and Malaysia led by David Cameron and Sajid Javid, which provided some interesting insights (if needed) into the workings of politicians. The business was halted by the Covid pandemic, but eventually recovered and was sold last year.

I am now enjoying retired life, focusing on health and fitness, traveling for fun and spending precious time with children and grandchildren. Is it really 50 years?

# Palmela Davis (McCullough)

Based in Belfast

I'm now Palmela McCullough, living in Belfast, married to Wesley, with two grown up sons Matthew and Ben .....and also very recently a little granddaughter Beattie.

I was so pleased to get to Friends' in 1969. My father had attended Wallace High School but as Friends' had a swimming pool I persuaded my mother it was the better of the two schools. How ironic as I came to dread swimming periods, an unheated pool with a terrifying teacher! Not to mention the bottle green swimsuit!

When I left Friends' in June 1976 I headed to Stranmillis College Belfast. There I completed a 4 year degree and opted to follow a career path in early years education. Most of my teaching years were spent at Inchmarlo Preparatory School Belfast. As it's the prep of The Royal Belfast Academical Institution I have often cheered my sons on ... to score against Friends'!

I retired recently - though go back for subbing.



Finally I have time to take tennis lessons and recently joined Wallace Park Tennis Club. Only a stone's throw from Friends' School Lisburn and a park I must have walked through many times in my uniform. I have been to Wimbledon, Queen's Club London and The Madrid Open. A trip to the Australian Open is definitely on my wish list.

50 years really have flown by but I'm pleased to say I remain in touch with quite a few of the "girls" from the Class of 1976!

# Anne Devonport

Based in Antwerp, Belgium

Started my professional career in the private sector as a P.A. in HQ of major international companies located in Brussels (11 years).

Joined the European Commission in 1988 where I worked for 28 years as a Civil Servant (trilingual Dutch/French/English P.A.) first in the DG (Directorate-General) for Energy and later in the DG for Transport in the Directorate dealing with Galileo (Europe's global satellite navigation system).

After my early retirement I relocated to Antwerp close to my son and 2 young granddaughters.

Keeping abreast of the latest medical research (especially regarding preventive medicine and epigenetics).

Took up painting (water colour/gouache) and enjoy city tripping around Belgium with friends, will be looking into volunteering next.



# Diane Drayne

Based in Belfast

After leaving school I completed an Art foundation course at Huddersfield Polytechnic and then studied Textile Design at the Art College in Belfast. From there, headed to London for teacher training, setting myself up for a life that would mix Art, adventure and a fair bit of unpredictability.

I began teaching Art and Design in England, but before long, the sunshine of the Bahamas came calling. Teaching there was an experience in itself - but even more life changing was meeting my husband who was at the University there. Together we returned to England for a time and we worked in different parts of the country, before taking a much bigger leap to his home in Trinidad and Tobago.

That's where life got interesting. My husband Richard was the manager of a Nature Reserve in the rain forest. I was a dab hand at helping the bird watchers identify the various species of birds, snakes and bats!! One day I might be guiding visitors to the bat cave on the estate, the next minute I could be found helping "snake man" to sew up an injured snake (proof the textiles came in handy!!) I worked at the Reserve until my teaching papers came through and then ended up teaching in the local teacher training College!!



Eventually, I returned to Belfast to teaching - though now I've happily swapped the classroom for my own art. These days being happily retired, I spend my time swimming, exercising, dancing and of course squeezing in as many travel adventures as possible.

# Ian Dring

Based in Aberdeenshire

After departing school I got a place to study Exploration Sciences at Nottingham University. It was there that I met Julie who was studying Geography and in the same halls of residence. My Dad worked as an Air Traffic Controller at Aldergrove Airport but at the beginning of second year he moved to Manchester Airport and our family relocated to Macclesfield, Cheshire.

I started work in the oil industry as a geologist but after a year I moved into the drilling side of the business spending six years offshore in the North Sea. 29 years in the office with Baker Hughes followed, with 21 years in Europe, 3 in Asia and 5 in Africa. I left Baker Hughes in 2015 and after a couple of unprofitable years with my own company I retired fully in 2018.

Julie and I married in 1983 and have two girls, Jennie & Laura. Jennie works for the NHS in Birmingham and Laura is a teacher up here in Aberdeenshire. We have two grandchildren Molly (8) and Thomas (5).



In my younger days I was a very keen squash player but that is now replaced by Pickleball. I am a member at Banchory Golf Club and play 4-5 times a week during the summer. The whole family ski and this Easter we are escaping Glenshee for Colorado.

We have had a house in the North East of Scotland for the last 36 years and seem busier than ever in retirement.

# Kathryn Farnham (Millinson)

Based in Anahilt

Born of good Ulster farming stock from County Tyrone and moving to Lisburn as a child as my father's financial career progressed in Accountancy.

After passing the dreaded transfer test I appeared at Friends' at the age of 11. I stayed through "O" level and "A" level years eventually studying Law at Queen's for 4 years. After graduating I attended the Institute of Professional Legal Studies to qualify as a Solicitor.



I worked in practices in Belfast City Centre, Newtownards, Downpatrick and ran a firm's office in Dromore for 13 years before moving back to Lisburn until retirement.

I married in 1989 to Chris, a Barrister, whom I met at the Institute of Professional Legal Studies, at Church in Lisburn. We built a home in Annahilt where we remain. I had 2 children, Elizabeth and Anna, both of whom attended Friends' Prep, with Anna following me to the Grammar whilst Elizabeth chose a different school to specialise in science.

Both daughters went to universities in England and Anna lives and works in England, is married and has a daughter Edith, aged 18 months, which makes me a Grandmother. Elizabeth is working here as an Animator.

What did I learn from all this?

Time flies.

# Norman Fleck

Based in Cambridge

After my time at Friends' I moved across the water to Cambridge, where I have lived ever since. Cambridge is a small city in the countryside, and having grown up in the countryside it was an easy transition. After an undergraduate degree in Engineering at Cambridge, I worked for 1 year in Rugby and in a village near Swansea for the metals Division of ICI, called IMI. Then, it was back to Cambridge for a PhD in metal fatigue, and post-doctoral work at Cambridge, Harvard University and NASA Langley, Virginia.



I am lucky: I much enjoy doing research (and teaching) in a University, and so I happily returned to Cambridge as a lecturer in 1985. Promotions followed in due course, and I have had a fun time working on a wide range of projects ranging from the failure of composite aerospace structures to the assessment of the potential failure of new bridges for HS2. I have found that consulting jobs and expert witness activity has kept me in touch with the 'real world' where Engineers make mistakes in design, manufacture and in operation. Unlike many of the class of '76, I am still working (by choice) but will finally retire when Cambridge chucks me out next year along with other Professors of this age.

On a personal note I have two fine kids Oliver and Anna from my first wife Vivien (who sadly died of cancer in 2007), and am now step-dad to two more fine kids Carl and Helen as a result of marrying a local GP Maureen in 2016. Family life continues to be fulfilling but there always seems to be one of them living at home, etc, etc!

# Alan Forsythe

Based in Edinburgh

After leaving Friends' I went to Queen's University and did a civil engineering degree. Not sure that civil engineering was for me and enjoying the student life, I stayed on to do a one year post graduate course in Computing on the basis that it would likely be worth knowing a bit about it going forward. I worked for the next few years in Belfast in a couple of small start ups and software houses before moving to Edinburgh with IBM.



A couple of years before this I had met my wife to be, Fay, at the wedding of a mutual friend in Yorkshire. Clearly written into the marriage contract was the requirement to move back to Belfast after two years, however 30+ years later we still haven't quite managed to achieve that! After leaving IBM I worked in a variety of technology and management roles in the energy and financial sectors in Scotland before hanging the boots up just before covid.

We have three children, the eldest Eleanor is married and works as a solicitor in Glasgow, Alexander, also married works in life sciences in Edinburgh, and our youngest, Charlotte is a teacher and is currently working in Dubai.

I've always enjoyed playing sport and still play golf, tennis and padel regularly although increasing badly and enjoy getting out walking.

I have a brother and sister living in Banbridge and get home to see them and NI friends very regularly.

# Des Gibson

Based in Helensburgh, Argyll & Bute

On leaving Friends' in 1976 I like many others in N Ireland progressed as a student at Queen's Belfast, studied pure & applied physics as an undergraduate and a follow-on PhD in optical thin film technology, graduating in 1979 and 1983 respectively. Subsequent to Queens I moved to Pilkington plc as an accelerated graduate recruit, initially within their photonics division based in Glasgow with follow-on roles in technology development & operations at Pilkington facilities worldwide – as a young engineer this provided an opportunity to globetrot for eight years with secondments in the US, China, Japan and Australia.

Marriage to a Glasgow girl Doris followed in 1994 and in 1996 the birth of twins, boy (Matthew) & girl (Hannah). After a comfortable corporate existence I joined a startup as co-founder / technical director - a leap of faith which required moving from secure employment prompted by full support from my wife (brave woman!) The company was fortunate to be acquired in 2002 at the height of the telecom boom – at this stage aged 44, the acquisition provided financial independence resulting in freedom of choice for future direction.

Since 2007 we have been located in Helensburgh, a sleepy hollow on the West coast of Scotland.

Motivated by fresh challenges and a desire to change lifestyle focus, in 2014 I moved into the university sector as a physics professor based in Glasgow – a shock to the system after 31 years in industry! Also more time to indulge my passion for classic UK sport cars.



Fully intend to grow old disgracefully prompted in particular by my family!

# Simon Gilbert

Based in North Yorkshire

I was at Friends' School, Lisburn, from January 1970 to Easter 1971. It wasn't a long stretch, but it was an important early step on the road and one I still remember fondly.

After school, I went straight into work, starting out in the motor trade. Things moved along quickly and, before I really knew it, I found myself running a dealership in my mid twenties. From there, life took a turn into healthcare and longterm care property — not exactly a childhood ambition, but a world I stayed in for the long haul.

Over the years, I worked with a wide mix of people and organisations, including care operators, local authorities and familiar names such as BUPA, Four Seasons, Bank of Scotland, Bank of Ireland and Northern Rock. I spent time with Christie & Co and Taylor National before setting up my own consultancy. I'm still involved today in advisory and non-executive roles, though with a bit more balance than in earlier years.

Life delivered a sharp reminder at 36, when I had a heart attack and a quadruple bypass — definitely one of those moments that makes you stop and rethink what matters.



On the brighter side, I met Fiona in April 1976. Fifty years later, we're still together, which feels like the biggest achievement of all.

Living in North Yorkshire, I enjoy cooking, drinking, eating and socialising, along with watching the odd game of rugby, and I'm really looking forward to catching up and hearing everyone else's stories.

# Maureen Gilliland (Kidd)

Based in Edinburgh

You could say that my story is one of redemption.

On leaving Queen's, I joined the Management Training Programme at Gallaher Ltd, a tobacco company. Unthinkable now. However, this was the 1980s, when padded shoulders and Princess Di hairstyles were not the only social crimes; a time when tobacco could advertise on 48-sheet posters and television as well as sponsor sport.

I then moved from marketing tobacco to marketing alcohol for Allied Distilleries (mine was a slow lane towards redemption), working on brands like Tia Maria. A move to Edinburgh with my husband, Colin Kidd (FSL alumnus; Class of '77) took me into advertising. I was Account Director for Drambuie Liqueur (still alcohol, but edging towards the light), Paterson's Shortbread (high fat, high sugar) and Scottish National Blood Transfusion Service (just perfect). I was then asked to join Drambuie Liqueur Ltd as their marketing lead (admittedly, a step backwards).

Giving birth in turn to Sarah, Thomas, and Daniel prompted a rethink about future career choices. I received a bursary to do a Masters in Public Health and took a job subsequently with NHS Health Scotland. Not only did I abandon booze and fags, but I worked on introducing the smoking ban in Scotland in 2006. I then became a board director and Chair of Cycling Scotland. Finally, I did a PhD around the Glasgow Commonwealth Games and post-doctoral research before full retirement.



Today I am doing the things that I enjoy most, with long-distance cycle touring top of my list. Safe to say, that's the only sort of 'pedalling' I am doing these days!

# Stuart Grayson

Based in Auckland, New Zealand

After that summer of sunshine in 1976 I studied physics & applied maths at Queen's, before going to Cambridge to do their Part III of the maths tripos, followed by a PhD in elementary particle physics. Subsequently, I had a 3-month grant from the Royal Society to visit an accelerator lab in Hamburg, where I started to learn German, before taking up a 3-year post-doc. in Durham, where I continued German night-classes through to A-level.

In Durham, I struggled to see myself in academia, and changed tack to move to Darmstadt in Germany working for an English software company, Logica. After 4 1/2 years, I was able to move to their newly created Zurich office in the project team developing an electronic stock exchange for Switzerland.

I loved Zurich, and ended up staying there for 22 years. I met Mirjam, who was head of HR at the Swiss Stock Exchange in 2001, and we got married in 2003. We have two children, Neal & Enya, both studying in Australia, despite having spent most of their school life in New Zealand. We had moved to Auckland in 2013 after several visits, including a 6-month trip in 2009.

I am about to retire from my work as an IT consultant, while Mirjam is building her online coaching and wellness business. I've lots of plans, including attempting the 1500km South Island stretch of NZ's Te Araroa hiking trail starting next January. I've always been interested in conservation work, and hope to volunteer in projects around Auckland, while also enjoying having time to read more about physics, astronomy and Antarctica.



# Barbara Hadden (Terry)

Based in London

After leaving school, I headed to Exeter University for three years I remember fondly, before training at St Thomas' Hospital in London and qualifying as a State Registered Nurse.

I traded the wards for the rather different demands of raising two children in London, and later found a happy second act working in the library of a local prep school — a role I kept up for nearly two decades before retiring in 2020.

I'm still in Wimbledon, still on the golf course, and still making regular pilgrimages back to Portballintrae. In between, I travel when I get the chance and make a point of keeping old friendships alive.

A highlight of recent years? Celebrating my Freedom Pass in proper style — travelling the entire length of Great Britain from John O'Groats to Land's End by public bus. Quite the adventure, and not a bad way to mark the occasion!

I'm very much looking forward to June.



# Susan Hayes (Boyd)

Based in Saintfield

When I left school all those years ago, I had no idea where life would take me. I began with a Business Studies course at the 'Poly' in Jordanstown, and since I was still playing lots of sport, I decided to stay on for another four years to complete a teaching degree.

After a few years teaching in various schools in and around Belfast, I specialised in dyslexia. I eventually became a senior teacher within a specialist service for the Education Authority, providing 1:1 support for children across Northern Ireland, training schools in creating dyslexia friendly environments, and contributing to a research project through part-time lecturing at Stranmillis College. Believe it or not, I'm still working as a supply teacher in several special schools today.

Like many of us back then, I married young — four days after my graduation. In fact, John and I will be celebrating our 44th anniversary this July. Our two children now live in Tallinn and Dublin, so we travel between both cities to keep our family connections strong.

I've always enjoyed spending time in the garden, travelling abroad, and heading up to the north coast most weekends to play golf.

Life, of course, has brought its share of ups and downs. I never won the lottery, nor did I manage to learn French (perhaps my GCSE grade 9 contributed to this) — but my Estonian is coming along surprisingly well!



# Pamela Hutchinson (Sainsbury)

Based in Harare, Zimbabwe

I graduated University College Cardiff LLB in 1979, and thereafter Law school in London in 1980. In 1983 I was admitted to the Law Society as a Solicitor, following Articles in Oxford.

In November 1985 I married Gavin whom I had met earlier that year on holiday in Zimbabwe. In 1986, I moved to Zimbabwe, where I joined Deloitte Harare. (I made a better accountant than lawyer!) In 1989 we welcomed a son, Michael, and in 1991 a second son Richard.



From 2005 to 2009, I experienced the hyper-inflationary years. In those years the country removed 26 zeros from the local currency! The highest denomination reached 100 trillion Zimbabwe dollars, which couldn't buy a loaf of bread! Shelves at supermarkets were empty, prices doubled every few hours, and the government were forced to de-monetize the currency and use the US\$.

Because of the children's passion for swimming, I started to get involved in swimming administration. After serving on various swimming committees, I was appointed the chairperson of the Zimbabwe Swimming Board of Control for several years. This was subsequently followed by an appointment as Vice President to the governing body, The Zimbabwe Aquatic Union. I also was very involved with the officiating side of swimming, participating in both national and international meets. This culminated on being appointed a recognized FINA international referee where I officiated in several meets, most notably the World Short Course championships, held in Dubai in 2010.

Following retirement in 2022, we enjoy travelling, especially to visit our two grandchildren.

# Sandra Ingram (Savage)

Based in Lancashire

After Friends' I went to University of East Anglia and did Maths. Then to London where I qualified as a Chartered Accountant, got married to Jon and had my first child. After 10 years in London, we moved to Manchester and I had my second child. 7 years ago we moved near Chorley in Lancashire to look after my Mum who is now 96.

After living in cities for 40 years, we now live on the edge of the countryside with 5 reservoirs within walking distance of our home. One son still lives in Manchester, and our other son is married with a toddler and lives in Newcastle upon Tyne, so we are making frequent trips to Northumberland.

I'm retired and volunteer at the local foodbank and at a Maths and English Functional Skills class. My Christian faith still plays a major part in my life, and we are involved in lots of Church activities.

No major claims to fame or life changing events to report!



I have 2 sisters who also went to Friends' – Doreen was in the year above and Stephanie was 2 years below. They have both lived in Edmonton in Canada for many years so we have had many holidays in Canada.

Thankful that when I joined Friends' in Year 3 (we had just moved to Lisburn from Rathfriland, and it was Friends' rather than Wallace that had spaces for all 3 of us!) I made good friends and enjoyed school. I have great memories of Sixth Form, especially classes with Mr Hunniford, Mr Kinkead and Mr Boyd. Only 3 girls doing Chemistry and Physics, so lots of fun!

# Frank Kee

Based in Templepatrick

As one of the Lurgan boys who came to Friends' on the train, I initially felt out of place but I needn't have feared because the pastoral care at school is what has stayed in my mind.

I attended Queen's University Medical School and left knowing that my future was going to be in Epidemiology and Public Health, which for most students is regarded as a minority sport (that is until the pandemic arrived!)



Nevertheless I completed my basic hospital medicine training in the Royal Victoria Hospital before completing specialist training and taking my first consultant post in Ballymena 1990.

Along the way, while working in RVH cardiology, I met and later married an outstanding nurse, Ann, who, after 47 years is still working in the RVH. We settled near Templepatrick and along came two daughters Emma and Beckie (now a psychiatrist and dentist – so that's old age taken care of, I hope) and then after some postgraduate time in Edinburgh and Baltimore, I later joined the staff of the Medical School as Professor in the Centre for Public Health in 1998.

What my time in academia has taught me is that the older I get, the more ignorant I realise I am, and the privilege of working in Public Health is that it is "everyone's business" and so everything needs to be on an interdisciplinary basis. My evolution to ignorance has echoes of my experience of golf – the older I get, the better I used to be, but let's just blame that on my hip replacement.

# Brian Lavery

Based in Liverpool

DISCLAIMER: Brian has not written 250 words since retiring from Freshfields Bruckhaus Deringer two years ago. Also, Brian has been pushed into writing by his good friend Julie (never a girlfriend sadly), so it needs a proofread.

Brian decided that he did not want to follow his father's career advice in 1975, and instead chose to swerve A-levels and take an electronics apprenticeship. Somewhat questionably he hooked up with an immigrant so as to live in her mother's house. By coincidence, on the day he left home, his father ran off with his fancy woman, thus negating Brian's strategy.



Brian has worked since then in various IT roles, starting as a technician at STP in Monkstown, then a brief spell at a music retailer (heavenly job), in between playing in bands on the show band circuit.

Trying to shake off the immigrant, Brian escaped to South Africa and spent eight happy years as a regional DP manager for the Sun City organisation (yes, that one, it was fantastic). There he met his next wife, had a son and decided to return to Blighty to work for Sheraton Hotels. There followed a daughter, and relocation to Brussels (Waterloo) for another seven heavenly years.

Around 1990 he returned to the UK, worked for Unilever for 18 years; BP for 6 years, and finally FBD for 5 years.

Children still speak to him, grandchildren abound, and he spends his time warbling around Merseyside with his guitar and band. And making sourdough...

# Jane Magowan (Wells)

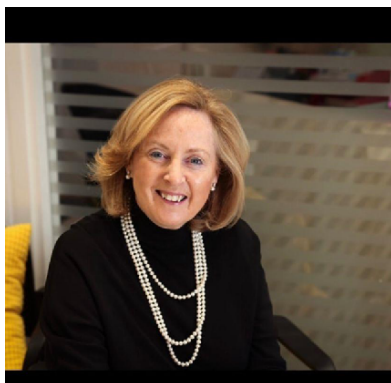
Based in Belfast

Work stuff.... Graduated from QUB 1981. Taught French in Jamaica. PGCE in QUB 1983 followed by 5 years teaching in Bloomfield Collegiate. Escaped the classroom in 1988, changed career to become a junior PR Consultant and progressed to buy the same company, JComms, in 2001. Was first female consultant in NI to be honoured with a Fellowship of Institute of PR and given a Lifetime Achievement Award in 2005. Appointed Deputy Lieutenant for Belfast in 2019. Awarded MBE in 2021. Retired 2022. Many career highlights but being involved in Trimble/Hume Nobel Peace Award in Oslo one of the best.

Family stuff.... Met Martin on a blind date in 1992 and married 11 months later! Have 3 lovely children, Sian, Duncan and Petra , and very lucky that they all live in Belfast. Looking forward to the birth of our first grandchild in September.

Fun stuff..... Having been a sporting non entity at school I discovered water skiing in my 20's, became hooked and ended up on the Irish Team. Ski jumping was my favourite event. Chaired Meteor Water Ski Club outside Lisburn and had a blast travelling round Ireland and UK competing with other like minded head cases.

Also enjoyed snow skiing and even navigated in a couple of night time rallies. For my 60<sup>th</sup> birthday I joined some other 'girls' and took up golf. What a revelation, absolutely obsessed!! Always challenging, never dull it has opened up a whole new world of social and holiday opportunities. Joined Malone post Covid and have never looked back. In anticipation of maturing years am now learning how to play bridge which is a total brain melter.



# **David McCabe & Vicky McCabe (née Hodge)**

Based in Dromore

David spent his years at Friends' as an observer. He can't recall a single ski trip, first eleven/fifteen appearance or even a walk-on part in the school play. He did almost make it to the end of year disco but Brown Shaw insisted that the smell of alcohol debarred entrance. He does, however, count it a privilege to have been taught by such characterful teachers and remains indebted to Art Teacher Barbara (Love) Smith, who recognised his ability to colour between the lines and arranged for him to attend the College of Art in Belfast, where he subsequently graduated with honours in 3D Design.

Vicky, on the other hand, took a somewhat more social and certainly more studious approach to her time at Friends'. She still maintains contact with some of her fellow students and took her biology classes seriously enough to pursue a career in Nursing - qualifying from the RVH in 1979. Her specialism in psychiatry and desire for a project may have contributed to her consenting to marry David in 1984. They settled in Dromore, County Down.

With a few more professional qualifications David proceeded to languish in public sector senior management, heading up various communication departments. David and Vicky enjoyed their schooldays at Friends' so much that they sent their three daughters to Banbridge Academy.

Both David and Vicky enjoy adventurous travel and have managed to cover most bases. While David toured museums and galleries in Russia, Vicky undertook voluntary work with orphanages in Ukraine. While Vicky nursed in Kfar Saba, Israel, David relished the splendours of Tehran, Shiraz and Isfahan in the Islamic Republic of Iran.

They haven't always been on opposing sides and together have ticked off a few wonders such as the Great Wall of China, the Taj Mahal in India, the Treasury of Petra, Jordan and the pyramids of Giza, Egypt. African travels have included bird-watching in The Gambia and self-drive safaris in the Kruger and beyond.

The aforementioned three daughters have now settled in Northern Ireland and have provided David and Vicky with seven grandchildren. David and Vicky still travel - Vicky now travels to Jordanstown on a Monday and Drumbo on a Wednesday while David visits Sandown Road on a Thursday.

Perhaps it's current affairs or perhaps an age thing but on reflection David and Vicky agree that the original Quaker worldview seems more compelling now than it did fifty years ago - Quae sursum sunt quaerite.



# Lorraine McMurray (Jess)

Based in Hillsborough

Studied French and German at QUB followed by PGCE. Spent a year in Paris as part of degree. Married Keith Jess (former FSL pupil) in 1981

After graduating went to live in Luxembourg for 3 years where first daughter was born in 1985. Worked in international banking in Luxembourg for Union Bank of Finland. This involved travelling to Helsinki. Came back to Northern Ireland in 1985 and resumed teaching career.

Second child - son born 1990. We have 3 grandchildren aged 10, 8 and 7 who live close by and attend FSL.

In retirement we enjoy travelling all over the world as well as spending a lot of time in Spain and the north coast of Ireland. Also enjoy walking and loved completing two sections of the Camino with a group of 12 friends. Play tennis 4 times per week. Enjoy cooking, eating healthily and keeping in touch with friends.



# Jane McVea

Based in Buckinghamshire

I don't think I made the most of school – too shy, too timid. Should have joined in more. But here is a note to that young self in a too big gym frock, long green knee socks and a bad hair cut.



It will turn out ok! You will go to university in Cardiff and on your first Saturday watch Wales v Argentina standing in the Arms Park. There will be many more rugby matches you get to go to over the next 40 years.

You will qualify as a pharmacist and have a career you loved, working in interesting jobs in hospitals all over England, finally working in quality improvement and supporting Trusts to develop new models of care.

Despite being terrified of heights, you will trek in the High Atlas Mountains and the Jordanian desert, among other places. You will spend six weeks walking solo across Sweden and Norway. 250 words are not enough to describe all the times you got stuck, cried, nearly gave up and then worked out how to go on.

When you eventually retire you will volunteer mentoring abused young people and in a high security prison monitoring the quality of care. At the present you spend one day a week sitting with people at the end of their life – so they don't die alone.

All in all it's been more fun than I could ever have dreamed. I won't be at the reunion because I will be in Helsinki trying to work out if I can drag these old bones on another solo trip next year into the Finnish interior. I hope you all have a fab time and celebrate that class of 76 was a pretty good year.

# George Munroe

Based in Donegal

After Friends' I studied Physics at Queen's Belfast, then completed a PhD. I used much computing in research, then helped others do the same in a range of disciplines, publishing articles on diverse and novel solutions. As a senior analyst, I managed campus wide software applications, including computer based learning. I became involved in the early development of internet applications with a global team. I started a private ISP in 1994 and established early "software as a service" applications, subsequently serving as founder or director in other local IT companies. I delivered training courses on internet services to international audiences.



From 2015–2019, I led a small team working for UK higher education, delivering IT infrastructure reviews across the mainland. Moved to Abu Dhabi in 2019 as director of enterprise applications for large UAE IT security company.

I returned in 2020 during the pandemic, easing into retirement since, spending more time on house, garden, music, motorbike, and holidays. Always keen on mountain walking, I've bagged summits in the Alps and Africa as well as British Isles. A regular half marathon runner until diabetes and prostate cancer imposed restraints. At 67 I'm taking up the challenge again and feeling fitter than at 17. I have three wonderful daughters (43, 41, 36) and five marvellous granddaughters (13, 9, 7, 4, 4). I spend a lot of time in Donegal—forest, mountain, sea. Soul mate, and fellow conspirator in most things, Christine is with me almost always. Any career I've had has been about the leverage of knowledge and technology to "do more things and do things better".

# Tracey O'Neill (Galway)

Based in Dromore

One week after leaving FSL I started work in the Northern Bank in Saintfield. I transferred to Shaftesbury Square, married in 1979 and when I started my family was retired.

I have 3 children. My eldest son teaches planning in QUB and has 2 young sons. My second son has his own business "Wee Critters" which educates schools, nurseries and anyone who will have him on animal welfare and conservation. Kerry, my youngest is in charge of the Medical Assessment Unit in the Lagan Valley. She has 2 children that I have regularly looked after to enable her to pursue her career.



Until retirement I did book keeping at home and was a partner in my husband's firm. I am involved in the W.I., N.I. Hospice support group and our church. I enjoy gardening, cross stitch, jigsaw puzzles and reading at home but love motorbiking, walking and sailing for outside pursuits. Maybe not the most exciting bio but to be happily married and enjoying life, family and holidays is good to me.

# Jane O'Sullivan (Sims)

Based in Essex

After leaving school, I spent 3 years studying Architecture in Liverpool before deciding it wasn't for me as I wanted to travel and I was never any good at maths. (Eric Shier once told me "You're a stupid goat and haven't a notion", which I found hilarious – and true!) I did a TEFL course in London and started my teaching life outside Barcelona, where I stayed for 2 years. After 2 further years in Madrid, I had a stint in Paris before returning to London to work in teacher recruitment. This was followed by a 5-year period in Oman, which I loved.



I came back to Colchester, where we had bought a house before going out to Oman. We divorced and I got a teaching and, later, management job in the local language school. During this time, I went out to Saudi to teach nurses.

(My second husband taught at the same school and had been sent out to Iraq for a short contract. He ended up as a hostage during the Gulf War.) I stayed in Colchester until 2017 when I took voluntary redundancy and retired – blissfully!

Now, my focus is on gardening, family research and more travelling.

# Paul Roberts

Based in Somerset

After FSL, I moved to Barrow-in-Furness, training at the shipyard for a year, and then on to Imperial College London to study Mechanical Engineering. Back to Barrow to complete the training scheme, and continued working there. I then moved on to various small firms in South Cumbria, designing equipment for subsea oil production in the North Sea and further afield. Also lots of walking in the fells of the Lake District, cycling, and dinghy sailing on Morecambe Bay and on Windermere and Coniston Water.



I married Sally in 1986 – we met at Imperial, but got together when she came to study for a PhD at Lancaster.

I had a spell of lecturing at Lancaster University, and then at UWE when we moved to Bristol. I then went back to the offshore oil industry, designing the control systems for subsea oil wells.

We both retired in 2020, as COVID lock-downs swept through the country. After a couple of years of searching, we retired to Wedmore – a fully-functioning village on raised land in the middle of the Somerset levels – we looked at so many villages that have been hollowed out and have lost all essential services.... I am still cycling, and sailing dinghies on Bristol Channel (second highest tides in the world!). And very much involved with the Men's Shed – we undertake useful projects around the parish, such as refurbishing benches, and installing kissing gates on footpaths.

# Timothy Smith

Based in Kent

Following a languages degree at Oxford (the highlight of which was a year in France) I found a job in insurance broking in London hoping to use my languages. I ended up specialising in construction insurance (for contractors and major projects). I spent 12 years in London and then had the opportunity to work in Hong Kong where there was a construction boom in the run-up to the 1997 handover to China. I spent 6 years there, before moving to Singapore in 1998 in a job took me round the various economies of SE Asia. Perhaps more importantly I met Angela in Hong Kong and we married in 1995. We returned to the UK in 2000 with two children, Patrick and Rachel. We ended up buying the first house we visited on a house hunting trip and have been living in Sevenoaks in Kent ever since.

I spent the next 20 years working for JLT in London, handling a range of clients including insurance assignments for the construction of the new Wembley Stadium and the London 2012 Olympics infrastructure and stadia.



I retired in 2020 and now spend my time volunteering, walking, gardening and teaching English to some Ukrainians. And I have recently started learning Italian. Angela and I enjoy travelling (especially to countries previously only visited on business) and try to see our children (who live in London) as regularly as possible.

With fewer links to Northern Ireland these days, I'm looking forward to coming back in June to meet everyone.

# Julie Smyth

Based in Hillsborough

After an enjoyable spell at Edinburgh University I joined the migration to London. I arranged overseas trade missions for London Chamber of Commerce, before being persuaded that banking was the route to getting a foot on the property ladder. I worked at Lloyds Bank for ten years, intended to be a job for life, but I was enticed to Danske Bank where I had the chance to explore the Nordic countries while arranging loans for Scandinavian corporates. I retired from Danske in 2014 after my job moved to Copenhagen and I had no desire to establish new roots for a fourth time in another city.

I returned home to NI as my parents reached the latter stages of their lives and I could support them. As I always enjoyed the hills and the sea, it became so much more accessible. I have completed some long-distance paths elsewhere too. Indoor interests include textiles and paint so I am a member of several groups, and have completed City & Guilds.



Nine years ago I took on the running of Hillsborough Art Society which often feels like real work, due to the time involved toiling over grant applications, but it is rewarding nonetheless because of the wide variety of Ulster artists I have welcomed. On a smaller scale I am a volunteer at Hillsborough Castle. I play golf several times a week, I share a sailing boat and there are endless opportunities to play bridge if one really wants to, not to mention the U3A!

# Michael Snoddy

Based in Moira

A “Class of 76” relay team entering the Belfast Marathon, was the start of my late in life running adventure. This 50 year old had started into something which was going to become a way of life.

Trips to Newcastle upon Tyne for the Great North Run had become an annual outing and it wasn't long before I had the urge to take on the 2015 Belfast Marathon. Belfast was followed by the Dublin Marathon later that same year and entry to the 2016 Edinburgh Marathon was made. My first European marathon was a trip to Greece, home of the marathon, with a start in the town of Marathon finishing in the iconic Panathenaic Stadium in Athens - originally built in 4th century B.C. then excavated and refurbished for the first modern Olympic Games in 1896.

One of my more interesting trips was to Ukraine last October, for the Kyiv Marathon. A country at war, but life goes on and their annual running festival helped to maintain some normality. A visit to the bomb shelter was required on my second night.

My most recent trip was to China for the Great Wall Marathon, probably the hardest marathon to date, the stunning scenery made up for 5,164 steps. I have now completed a total of 70 marathons in seventeen countries.



Aside from the running, I completed the eight day trek to Everest Base Camp in 2022.

Time to slow down...?  
Perhaps.

*Kiev Marathon 2025 Finish  
Line*

# Hugh Suffern

Based in Banbridge

After leaving Friends' I enrolled at Trinity College Dublin to study Veterinary medicine. Five great years spent partying on the proceeds of the northern student grant and riding horses in between - not so much academic endeavour!

I have spent the rest of the past 50 years in County Down. My wife and I set up a stud farm and equine veterinary clinic in Banbridge which was busy for many years breeding thoroughbreds and more importantly paying off the mortgage on the farm and the new veterinary clinic. During this time I had great craic travelling as Irish team vet to numerous World Championships and Olympic Games.



Two years ago just as life was settling down nicely, Alison my wife started to behave a little oddly, a little eccentric. Shortly after she was diagnosed with a rare form of early onset dementia, a cruel fate for someone so vibrant and full of life. The long goodbye. Whilst it is not what I would ever have wished for, strangely it is an absolute privilege to care for Ali now. Payback for a lifetime of her love and devotion to me and our two children.

All of the self-help books recommend that the carer must take time for their own well-being. I know this to be true, if I am feeling low it pulls Ali down too. The advice was for perhaps a 10 minute walk each day - training for and completing an Ironman was, on reflection an extreme interpretation of this advice!

I am now making plans to retire. Hopefully my son is returning from Newmarket next year with his wife and daughter to take over the clinic.

Life has been and continues to be, a blast.

# Chris Swain

Based in Moira

I have very fond memories of Friends'. Perhaps the clearest early sign of things to come was a Prep School report from my class teacher, who wrote that if Christopher put as much effort into doing what he was asked as he did explaining why he should not have to do it, he would go far.



It was, perhaps, an early glimpse of the independent streak leading to self-employment, which has suited my non-conforming nature. It has brought me freedom and self-reliance, together with full responsibility for the good and bad decisions I alone have made.

A lifetime of self-employment has taught me that good judgement comes from experience, which often comes from poor judgement. I value my failures every bit as much as any perceived successes. My greatest success is my wonderful family, and my wife and soulmate has somehow “survived” more than 40 happy years of marriage with me.

My life is a modest and happy one, enriched daily by our rewilded garden close to a mature rookery. I have many interests, including learning Irish, exploring Irish archaeology, hill walking, wildlife photography in wild and remote places, particularly the Irish and Scottish isles, and boating on the Shannon-Erne waterways. A more recent passion project is a peace initiative with which I am involved.

Above all, I have valued a life in which my time has truly been my own, giving me space to think, reflect and philosophise. As I write this, I am 25,017 days old. I treasure every one of them and, at my age, am consciously grateful for each new day.

# Steven Swain

Based in Kinross-shire

After studying civil engineering at Ulster Polytechnic and Dundee University I made Scotland my home and married Allison (from Whiteabbey) in 1988 with Fraser being born in 1989 and Rebecca in 1993. In 1991 I was given the opportunity to work in Oman. Allison, Fraser and Rebecca returned to Scotland in 1996 and I returned at the beginning of 1998 to work in the Shetland Islands. I worked with contractors until 2001 with some short trips to India and Hong Kong. In the main I was working on maritime projects and also some in roads/bridges, rail and nuclear sectors.



Between 2001 and 2018 I worked with engineering consultants again in the main on maritime projects but also in nuclear, infrastructure, shipbuilding and water supply/distribution sectors on projects located in UK, Bahrain, France, Qatar, Ghana and Brazil with some short term international assignments and 2 longer 18 month stints living in Qatar.

I have worked with some incredible people / teams on fantastic projects. The highlights were probably my brief involvement in the ITER fusion reactor, Cadarache, France; leading a multi international design team to develop a new city (Lusail), Qatar and being part of the Project Management Consultant team supporting the Supreme Committee, Qatar 22, preparing for the World Cup, which commenced ten years in advance of the tournament. The opening ceremony and final were held at the new stadium constructed in the city of Lusail which I had been involved with some 15 years previously.

# Maggie Thompson

Based in Esquimalt, BC, Canada

I began attending Friends' in 1966. It took 70 minutes to get there by bus. My family moved to Dawson Creek BC in 1974, I became a boarder and stayed with relations and good friends like Jenny and Jane on weekends. Upon leaving Friends' I studied Town and Country Planning at U of Manchester. I moved permanently to Canada in 1978 finishing my degree at the University of Waterloo in 1981.



I had two careers really. I was a social planner and activist with non profit societies such as the Canadian Cancer Society, and Children's Aid eventually focusing on Women's Health. I co-founded the Canadian Women's Health Network, and Everywoman's Health Clinic and was most proud to assist 5000 Canadian women sue AH Robins in US Court for damages caused by the Dalkon Shield IUD; I helped press for changes in Federal Legislation on Women's Reproductive Health and Dying with Dignity.

By then I was 42, single, with a wonderful 15 year old daughter. That's when I opened Claddagh House B&B in Victoria. After 5 years of hilariously hard work I realized I never got out of the house so I became a Realtor. Soon I was hardly home. After 10 years in real estate I thought "whew, that time went fast" so I decided to fulfil an old dream earning a Masters in Peace & Conflict Studies at the U of Ulster. I retired from paid work in 2016

I live in a dear old cottage with a huge garden I adore. I'm blessed with my husband Vick, our cat Mia, and my daughter Cecile, an LA musician and producer. Though I've had serious health problems, I feel lucky to have lived the past 67 years, what a time it's been. I am firm in the belief that "a life well lived is long enough" *Seneca*.

All the best to you all dear Friends.

# June Turner (Champion)

Based in Hillsborough

Took a year out and enjoyed being with wider family and my horses before starting nurse training in the RVH in September 1977. Married in May 1980 and we have two lovely daughters. I qualified as a RGN in November 1980.

After qualifying, I had 19 years clinical practice in the RVH. Initially as a staff nurse in the Regional Burns Unit and then as a Theatre Sister (predominantly in Neurosurgery). BA (Hons) Public Policy and Management obtained in 1998. Appointed as first Clinical Risk Manager in the RVH in 1999 and from 2003 added health and safety, ergonomics, emergency planning, standards and guidelines, clinical audit and claims management to the role. Masters in Claims and Risk Management (LLM) in Healthcare in 2006.

Appointed as Co Director Risk and Governance for Belfast HSC Trust in 2007. In 2009, added role as Acting Head of Office for the Trust. Retired from this post in June 2014. Since then, I have been an Associate with the HSC Leadership Centre working with the DoH and across the Health and Social Care system in NI.

To relax, as a family we spend time in Fermanagh boating around the Erne Shannon waterways. We still have horses but only my husband and youngest daughter still compete. Love gardening and reading (mostly crime which says something I fear), dry white wine or 'bubbles' to accompany the above relaxation therapies!



# Rodney Turtle

Based in London

After leaving school, I studied engineering and began my career in the oil industry, spending ten years with Shell—first in the Netherlands, then across the Middle East. Those years developed my technical skills in challenging environments and with global teams. An MBA in Switzerland marked the change, leading to commercial business roles and a wider perspective.



That took me to Schneider Electric, where I spent decades in strategy, marketing, and M&A, before moving to head our public policy function. There, I helped form positions on energy efficiency, electrical safety, and sustainability, working with politicians, regulators, and trade bodies. I retired recently but remain involved, chairing three of the company's pension schemes.

Key roles included representing the UK on the Council Board of the International Electrotechnical Commission (IEC), serving as President of BEAMA (the UK electrotechnical trade association), and chairing BSI's Electrotechnical Standardization Strategic Advisory Council—positions that combined my engineering background with policy work.

Now, I live in leafy Barnes, west London, with Nora, our daughter Yerus, and dog Honey. Photography, travel, golf, and family time fill my days. I reflect gratefully on how our school days led to a lifetime of curiosity and connection.

# Paul Waterworth

Based in Lisburn

I am married and live in Lisburn.

After leaving Friends' I went to Tech for two years. I started work as an electrical engineer in 1974 and worked for various electrical companies throughout my career before I retired on 31st March 2026.

My hobbies are walking our dog, golf, dining out and going on cruises.



# Brian Wilson

Based in Lisburn.

After leaving school I joined the family company and was lucky enough to travel the world really. I have lived in Dublin and then in Baghdad Iraq for a while before settling back at home but continued to travel extensively.

Got married and had 3 children, split up and had another child from a new relationship, he is eighteen now and keeps me on my toes!

The family company was very successful and sold to Caterpillar from the USA in 1994, I continued to work with CAT until around 2009 and since then I have been acting as a freelance consultant in the energy business as well as running my own farm which is a beef enterprise. I have also dabbled in breeding thoroughbred horses from time to time.

My health has been generally good but in 2002 I was diagnosed with an acoustic neuroma which is a benign brain tumour and went through an 18-hour operation to have it removed but here we are in 2026 and I am still working away and enjoying life!

I have travelled so much during my career I have no real desire to do a lot more but enjoy breaks in Europe and may try a cruise for my 70<sup>th</sup> birthday which is not far away! I feel blessed in the life I have had and think of some schoolmates who did not make it this far.



*Brian (centre) with younger brothers Michael and Scott.*

# Jennie Wilson (Robertson)

Based in Morvern, West Highlands



After a degree and PhD in archaeology at the University of Edinburgh, I moved to Morvern, in the West Highlands of Scotland, where my husband Angus had taken a job as manager of a 35-square mile estate. Intending to fill in just for six months, he finally retired after 35 years. I worked, in what became known amongst my family as “A Career in Ruins”, as a self-employed archaeologist, undertaking field surveys of areas of land around the Highlands, prior to afforestation or construction, to identify any archaeological remains at risk.

Morvern is a peninsula, opposite the island of Mull with a total population of 320 and our village of Lochaline is reached via 20 miles of single track road. While rather remote, there is a terrific sense of community and it was a great place to raise our three daughters Isla, Lisa and Flora, now 35, 32 and 30. Angus and I have both been involved in our community company, which is about to use profits from its own hydro scheme to build some houses in the village. For such a small population, there is an amazing amount going on with singing and music groups, dancing and yoga, watersports, history and woodland groups and now a community cafe, gym and sauna.

All three daughters came home during Covid and Isla now lives in the village with her partner and 3 year old daughter. The imminent arrival of another grandchild, due in early June, may well stymie my attendance at the dinner!

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